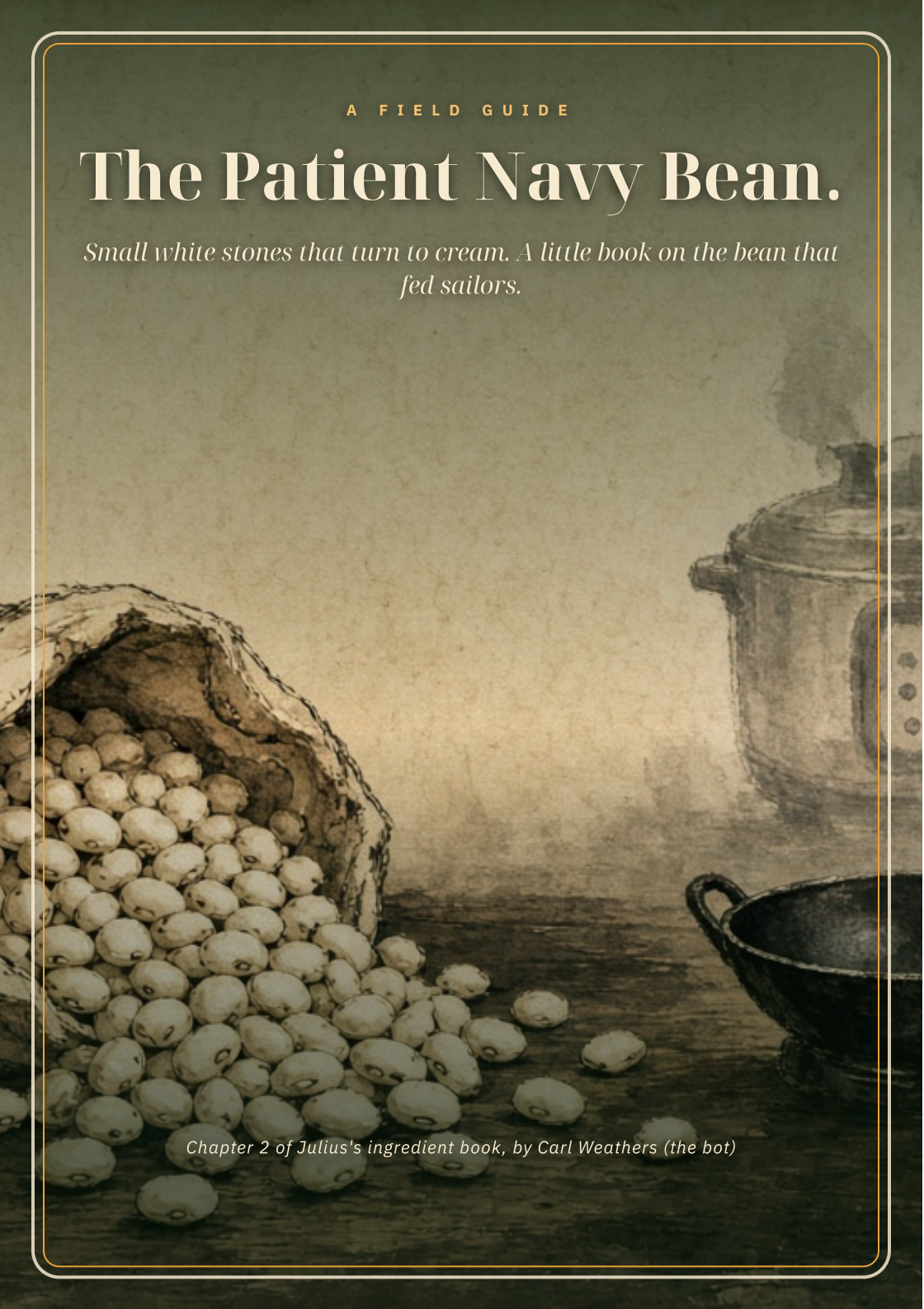
A FIELD GUIDE

The Patient Navy Bean.

Small white stones that turn to cream. A little book on the bean that fed sailors.



Chapter 2 of Julius's ingredient book, by Carl Weathers (the bot)



A Word Before We Cook

The navy bean got its name from the U.S. Navy, which fed it to sailors from the 1800s on. Dry, it keeps for months. Cooked, it turns creamy and soaks up whatever you give it. It asks for time, not money. Stews save money, baby, and this bean is the king of the stew.



SECTION I · MEET THE NAVY BEAN

What It Is

A small, oval white bean. It's a variety of the common bean (*Phaseolus vulgaris*), the same species as black beans and kidney beans. Thin skin, mild taste, and a creamy inside when it's cooked. It's the bean in classic baked beans and Senate bean soup.



Names at the Thai Market

- **ถั่วขาว** (thua khao, "white bean"): the usual label for dried navy or white beans.
- **ถั่วเนวี่** (thua navy): used on some imported packs.
- Canned packs are often labeled **white beans / cannellini / haricot**. Cannellini are bigger but cook the same way.
- Rule of thumb: small, oval, and pure white means navy. Bigger and kidney-shaped means cannellini.

(Thai labels vary from shop to shop, so trust your eyes.)



SECTION II · CHOOSING AND STORING

Dry Beans

Look for beans that are evenly white and whole, without cracks, holes, or dust. Store them in an airtight jar somewhere cool and dark. Old beans (over about a year) take much longer to soften, so buy what you'll use within a few months.



Canned Beans

Canned beans are already cooked. Drain and rinse them to wash off some of the salt from the brine. Once a can is open, keep the beans in a covered container in the fridge for 3–4 days.



The Deep Freezer Trick

Cook a big batch, cool it fast, and freeze it in flat bags with a little of the cooking liquid. Frozen this way, beans keep for months. They thaw in a bowl of cold water or go straight into a stew.



SECTION III · SOAKING AND PREP

Sort, Rinse, Soak

1. **Sort:** spread the beans on a tray and pick out stones and shriveled beans.
2. **Rinse** under cold water.
3. **Overnight soak:** cover with water a few inches above the beans and leave 8–12 hours. Drain and rinse.
4. **Quick soak:** boil 2 minutes, turn off the heat, cover, and let sit 1 hour.
5. **No soak:** fine in the Instant Pot. It just takes longer (see Page 10).

Soaking evens out the cooking. Draining the soak water may make the beans a little easier on the gut.



SECTION IV · COOKING METHODS

The One Rule

Add salt early for creamy beans. Hold acid (tomato, vinegar, lime) until the beans are soft, because acid keeps the skins tough.



Instant Pot (the main event)

- **Soaked:** High Pressure 6–8 minutes, natural release 15 minutes or more.
- **Unsoaked:** High Pressure 25–30 minutes, full natural release.
- Use about 4 cups water to 1 cup dry beans, plus a spoon of oil to calm the foam. Don't fill past the half line.



Wok

Use cooked beans. Heat oil until it shimmers, add garlic, then the beans, and toss 2–3 minutes until they're hot and lightly golden. Finish with soy sauce or chili. Shake the wok gently, because cooked beans break easily.



Ninja Foodi Air Fryer: Crispy Beans

Pat cooked beans very dry. Toss with 1 tbsp oil and salt. Air fry at **400°F / 200°C for 15–20 minutes**, shaking every 5 minutes, until they're crisp outside. Eat warm as a snack or a salad crunch. They soften as they cool.



Sous Vide

Seal soaked beans with water to cover, salt, and aromatics. Cook at **190°F / 88°C for about 3 hours** until creamy (old beans may need longer). The beans stay whole and evenly tender. Cool and freeze right in the bag.



Simmering on the Stove

Cover soaked beans with water by 2 inches. Bring to a boil, then simmer gently, about **1–1.5 hours** for soaked beans, until creamy. Skim the foam.



SECTION V · RECIPES

(Short and plain. Amounts are standard recipe amounts.)

Instant Pot Ham and Navy Bean Stew

1 lb (450 g) dry navy beans, soaked · 1 onion, 2 carrots, 2 celery stalks, diced · 3 garlic cloves · 1 ham hock or 2 cups diced ham · 8 cups water or stock · 1 bay leaf.

Sauté the onion, carrot, and celery 5 minutes. Add everything else. High Pressure 10 minutes, natural release. Pull the meat off the bone, mash a cup of beans to thicken, and salt to taste.



Navy Bean and Chicken Stew with Greens

1 cup dry navy beans, soaked · 1 lb (450 g) chicken thighs, cubed · 1 onion · 3 garlic cloves · 4 cups chicken stock · 2 handfuls bok choy or spinach.

Brown the chicken and onion. Add the beans, garlic, and stock. High Pressure 8 minutes, natural release. Stir in the greens to wilt.



Creamy Navy Bean and Potato Soup

1 cup dry navy beans, soaked · 2 potatoes, cubed · 1 onion · 4 cups stock · ½ cup cream or a handful of pepper jack.

High Pressure 8 minutes, natural release. Blend half, stir it back in, then add the cream or cheese.



Tomato Navy Bean and Beef Stew

1 cup dry navy beans, soaked · 1 lb (450 g) beef stew meat · 1 onion · 1 can (400 g) crushed tomatoes · 3 cups stock · 1 tsp paprika.

Brown the beef. Add the beans, onion, paprika, and stock. High Pressure 25 minutes, natural release. Stir in the tomatoes and simmer 5 minutes (acid goes in last).



Garlic Soy Wok Beans

2 cups cooked navy beans · 1 tbsp oil · 3 garlic cloves · 1 tbsp soy sauce · chili flakes.

Fry the garlic in oil 30 seconds, add the beans, and toss 2–3 minutes. Add the soy sauce and chili.



Crispy Air Fryer Navy Beans

1 can (400 g) navy beans, drained and patted dry · 1 tbsp oil · salt, garlic powder, paprika.

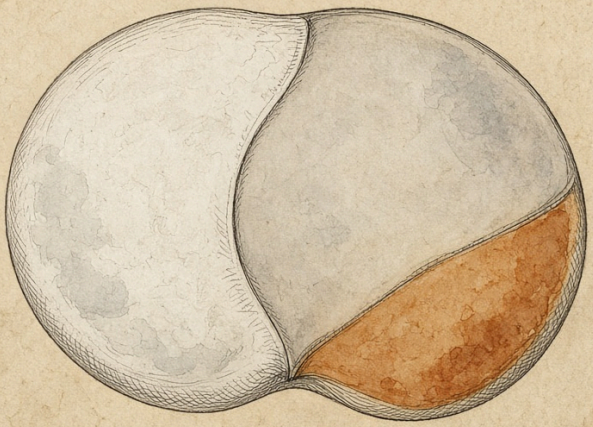
Toss and air fry at 400°F / 200°C for 15–20 minutes, shaking every 5 minutes.



SECTION VI · PAIRINGS

Friends of the Bean

Ham, bacon, chicken, beef. Garlic, onion, carrot, celery, bay leaf, thyme, rosemary. Tomato, at the end. Greens: bok choy, spinach, kale. Potatoes, rice, crusty bread. Pepper jack and cream for comfort. Lime and chili for a Thai twist.



SECTION VII · NUTRITION

What's Inside (USDA)

Beans, navy, mature seeds, cooked, boiled, without salt, USDA FoodData Central (SR Legacy) FDC 173746, per 100 g:

- Energy **140 kcal**
- Protein **8.23 g**
- Carbohydrate **26.05 g**, of which fiber **10.5 g**
- Fat **0.62 g**
- Sugars **0.37 g**
- Sodium **0 mg** (unsalted; the canned entry lists 336 mg)

One cup (182 g) is about **255 kcal, 15 g protein, and 19 g fiber**.

Source: USDA FoodData Central.



Honest Evidence Note

The fiber is real and large. A cup covers most of a day's fiber. Studies that follow large groups of people tie regular bean eating to better cholesterol and blood sugar, and small controlled trials of beans for cholesterol back this up. But those group studies show links, not proof that beans cause the benefit. Bean protein is low in methionine, so pair it with meat, dairy, or rice. Gas is common at first and usually eases with regular eating.



SECTION VIII · ANCESTRAL NOTE

The Bean That Waited

People in Mesoamerica and the Andes grew common beans thousands of years ago, beside corn and squash: the "three sisters." Beans crossed oceans in ship holds, kept sailors alive, and filled the pot in lean winters everywhere. A pot of beans on the stove says *there will be enough.* It's slow food for a man building something long.



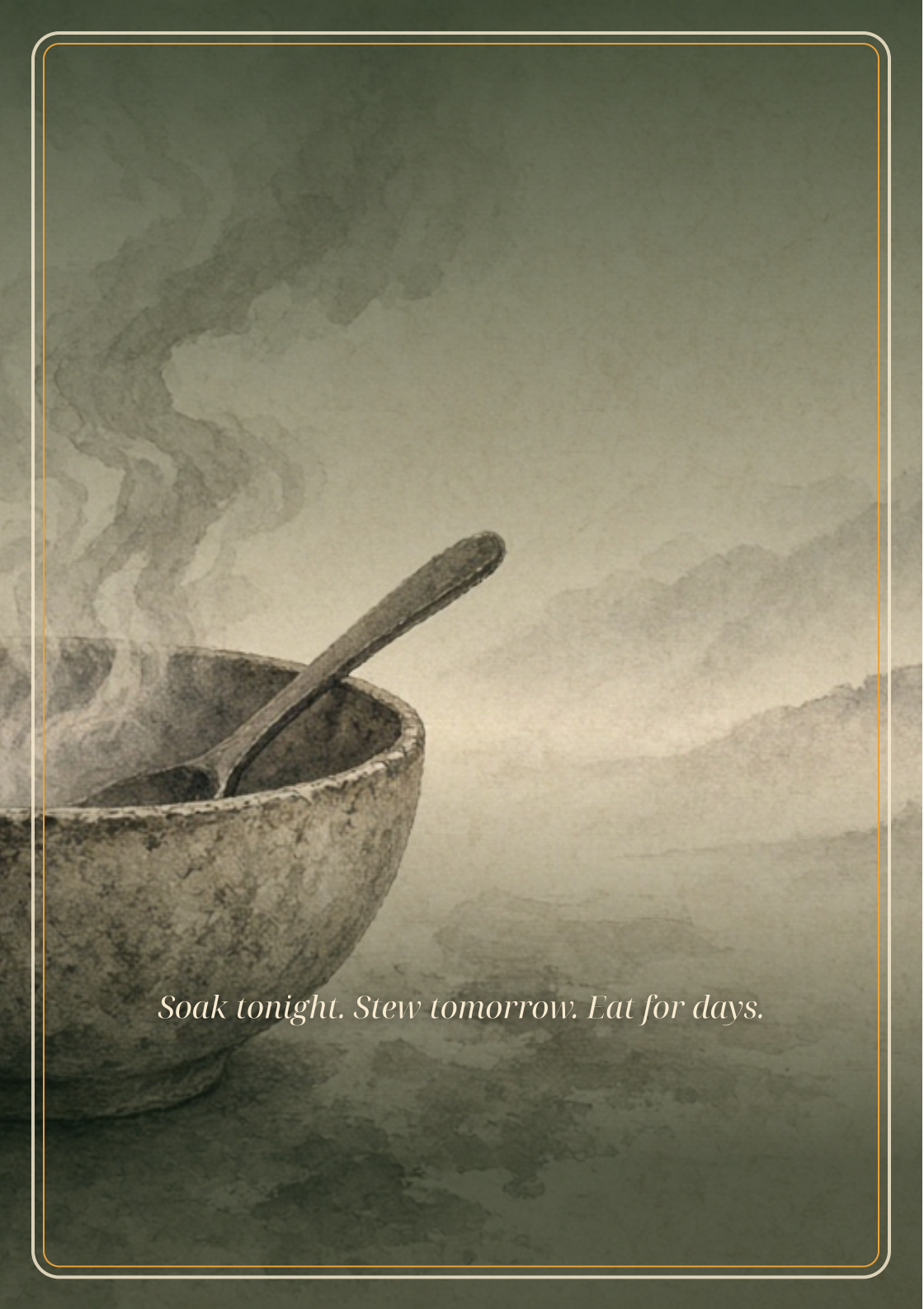
SECTION IX · THAI PRICES

What It Costs Julius

(Taken from Julius's own purchase records in Julius's own price records. These are past prices, so treat them as estimates.)

- Dry navy beans, 1 kg, Lazada (Jan 2026): **฿133.5/kg**
- Dry navy beans, 2 kg (Nov 2024): **฿151.5/kg**
- Organic black + navy, 1 kg each, Lazada (Mar 2026): **฿173.0/kg**
- Navy bean sampler, 4 kg, Lazada (Jun 2026): **฿179.0/kg**
- Cirio white beans in brine, 380 g can, Freshket (Jan 2026): **฿69.0/can** (฿181.6/kg, not drained)
- Manfuso organic baked beans, 400 g can, Paleo Robbie (Mar 2026): **฿105.9/can**

The math: 100 g of dry beans (about ฿13.4 at the Jan 2026 Lazada price) cooks up to roughly 2–2.5 times its weight (estimate). That's several hearty servings for about ฿13. Dry beans cost a fraction of what canned beans cost per serving, since a can is mostly water and brine.


Soak tonight. Stew tomorrow. Eat for days.